

THE UNION TIGHTENS ITS GRIP

1863

The nature of the war changed decisively with President Lincoln's Emancipation Proclamation on the first day of 1863.

Slavery had been the war's principal cause, and now a Union victory would mean its effective abolition. The mobilization of Black troops would also bring an important addition to Union numbers on the battlefield. After all the disappointments and command changes of the previous months, 1863 saw the Union begin to deploy its greater strength with real effectiveness, with Lincoln at last finding the commanders with the administrative competence and ruthless aggressiveness to bring this power to bear.

The Confederacy until now had had most of its successes in the Eastern Theater, but was clearly under pressure elsewhere. The Union blockade was growing ever tighter, and Union forces were advancing steadily up and down the Mississippi. By year's end, after the succession of great and by no means one-sided battles, the Union clearly held the initiative in both of the war's main theaters. The Deep South lay open to attack, and Lee's army in Virginia could only expect to fight yet more battles against heavy odds.

The nature of the fighting was also increasingly taking on the characteristics that would dominate the wars of the industrialized 20th century—strategic maneuvers and the movement of supplies of mass armies being made by rail, and the battles of these armies being centered on fighting for entrenchments under ferocious artillery bombardments.

The North still had weaknesses. Social and racial tensions were made plain by the Draft Riots, but the home front in the South was more vulnerable with galloping inflation and food shortages. Southern prospects for 1864 were turning bleak.

